



DiRT™

Rating: 8/10 Developer: Codemasters, Publisher: Codemasters,
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The Road Less Travelled

Colin McRae: *DiRT* is undoubtedly one of the best-looking car games for the PC. Unlike other racing titles, this one has nothing to do with story-lines, creating mansions, or playing fairy godmother in a fantasy world. *DiRT* is the latest and probably the most anticipated of all the Colin McRae Rally releases. It's one that's come out on gaming consoles alongside the PC.

The entire game is based around tiers or levels. You make your way to the end of the game by scoring points on a tier through races, time trials, or super specials. The reason I'll be using the term "vehicle" is that *DiRT* isn't only cars—there are buggies and trucks, too, which takes the game to an all-new level! In fact, there are 13 classes of vehicles: FWD, RWD, 4WD, Classics, and more. You go through plenty of tiers and levels before you finish the game. When you do complete them you can dive straight into the multi-player game on the Internet or on a local network.

The handling of the cars and trucks differs a lot from one to the other. The slower cars, like the Fiat Punto, are extremely difficult when you first try them.

They react aggressively to tiny inputs, which results in you swinging from side to side hitting guardrails even on a straight road. This coupled with wet roads means you've really had it... The trucks and buggies have a rather unique, sim-like feel.

DiRT isn't an easy game to start with even at the Rookie level. The damage levels and AI difficulty increases as you go up the levels. It takes a while before you can hold the cars by the scruff of the neck and throw them around the place.

Looks-wise, *DiRT* is fantastic. The models are well-detailed, and this can be noticed when you scrape your vehicle on rocks alongside the track or into walls, which results in shedding of panels of your vehicle and exposing of the insides. Fallen pieces of mangled metal and other wreckage you and other players cause lie scattered all around the track. It can become an obstacle course at times—you need to be careful not to run over them while making a second round through the track. Dents and folds on the metal appear when you bang your vehicle onto something a little more solid. The sensation of holes being pieced into my retina was proof enough that the HDR effect was being shamelessly abused in *DiRT*.

It's really bright and distracting when it's really sunny in-game. The tracks are unique and pretty long as well, which adds some amount of the authenticity of rally car racing.

There's even the legendary Pikes Peak track!

We substituted our temporarily indisposed 8800 Ultra with a GeForce 7900GTX on our gaming rig for this—the game will make any machine beg for mercy—frame rates at 1440 x 900 were nothing more than 20 fps with the quality turned all the way up, but without any multisampling.

There are some nice details in the sounds: the turbo whine gets louder as the rpm reaches the peak. Drive under a bridge or along narrow streets and you immediately get the audio feedback from the change in ambient environmental sounds.

DiRT isn't perfect by any means. Many of the cars have very odd handling, and the game doesn't seem to have been optimised enough. Once upon a time, the Colin McRae series was considered the ultimate rally simulation. Ever since Richard Burns Rally arrived in the second half of 2004 and took over CMR's place, it hasn't been dethroned from its perch, and we're sad to announce it still fails. This isn't necessarily a bad thing for *DiRT*: it's is great, and can be really good fun once you get the hang of it. I'm sure the ecstatic crowd of drooling gamers and non-gamers gathered behind me waiting for their turn will agree with me with thumps on the table.

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